

African zorilla

Ictonyx striatus

- ↔ 11–15 in (28–38 cm)
- 📍 W. to E. and Southern Africa
- ⊗ Common

The zorilla resembles a small skunk, both in appearance and in its defense tactics. Like a skunk, it drives away attackers by spraying them with a foul secretion from its anal glands, while hissing and screaming. Mainly nocturnal, it digs out prey such as insect grubs from among dead leaves with its long front claws.

Honey badger

Mellivora capensis

- ↔ 24–30 in (61–76 cm)
- 📍 W., C., E., and Southern Africa, W. and S. Asia
- ⊗ Common

The martenlike honey badger has a striking two-tone pattern of silver-gray upperparts, sharply contrasting with black below. It eats a variety of prey ranging from insect grubs to snakes and porcupines, but it owes its name to its taste for



wild honey. It digs large burrows, but may also live in rock crevices and holes in tree roots. It defends

itself fearlessly, sometimes producing an offensive smell to deter predators.

Greater grison

Galictis vittata

- ↔ 19–22 in (48–56 cm)
- 📍 S. Mexico, Central and northern South America
- ⊗ Common

Grizzled gray above and black below, with a white U-shaped stripe dividing the two on its forehead and neck, this is a sleek, sinuous hunter with a slim, pointed head and relatively short legs. An agile runner, swimmer, and climber, it forages on the ground, usually by day, for small mammals such as agoutis and opossums, as well as insects, worms, frogs, birds, and some fruit. It usually lives alone, or in pairs. Its sounds include snorts, growls, screams, and barks.

American badger

Taxidea taxus

- ↔ 17–28 in (43–71 cm)
- 📍 SW. Canada to US, N. Mexico
- ⊗ Common

Like other badgers, this species is stocky and powerful, with short, strong legs, shaggy gray fur, and

a black-and-white striped face. It usually lives on open grasslands, where it uses its powerful claws to dig for burrowing prey such as ground squirrels, pocket gophers, voles, and even ground-nesting birds, such as burrowing owls. It also eats a lot of insects and some seeds. It typically forages at night, spending the day in a burrow.



Hog badger

Arctonyx collaris

- ↔ 22–28 in (55–70 cm)
- 📍 SE. and E. Asia
- ⊗ Near threatened

This forest dweller has a long, black-striped white face with a pink, piglike snout and protruding lower teeth—the ideal tool for digging in soft soil for insect grubs, worms, seeds, and juicy roots. It also seizes other small animals, such as mice. It is an expert digger, using its very long front claws to create elaborate burrow systems. A nocturnal species, it spends the day sheltering in these burrows. The hog badger regularly falls prey to tigers and leopards but fights back vigorously if cornered.

Sea otter

Enhydra lutris

- ↔ 22–51 in (56–130 cm)
- 📍 North Pacific
- ⊗ Endangered

The heaviest of all otters but the smallest marine mammal, the sea otter hunts in coastal seas. Its extremely dense fur keeps it warm, enabling it to stay at sea for many hours. It hunts for shellfish such as clams and especially the sea urchins that swarm beneath the submerged forests of giant kelp (seaweed) that grow in north Pacific coastal waters. Bringing the shellfish to the surface, it often breaks them open with a stone, while floating on its back.

African clawless otter

Aonyx capensis

- ↔ 29–37 in (73–95 cm)
- 📍 W., E., C., and Southern Africa
- ⊗ Common

This otter has short claws on its hindfeet, but its clawless front toes are more like fingers, with a sensitivity that enables the animal to feel for prey in muddy water. The otter's long, sinuous body and muscular tail make it an excellent swimmer and diver, allowing it to chase after fish and frogs underwater. It also preys on crabs and lobsters on coasts, cracking their shells open with its strong jaws.

